

An audience familiar with the roles of femmes fatales in earlier noir movies would naturally assume the same. But Mrs. Mulwray is the real victim, and the truth is so unsettling that Gittes can barely take it in. The real villain of the piece, it turns out, is the seemingly urbane old man Noah Cross, Evelyn's father. He is the wealthy man whose determination to use the city's water

supply to his own advantage leads to the murder of his former business partner, Evelyn's husband Hollis Mulwray.

Unexpected twist

There is a twist at the end of *Chinatown* that makes the movie disturbingly

different from other crime thrillers, and makes it linger long in the mind. In most movies about power and corruption, the detective simply homes in on, and then exposes, those responsible for a crime and its cover-up. But at the crucial moment in *Chinatown*, the focus is diverted away from Cross's efforts to control the water supply. Instead, we are faced with a shocking revelation that appears to come out of the blue. Right at the end of the movie, we are left with the deeply disturbing image of Cross—who appears to have got away with everything—comforting his granddaughter.

Controlling men

Chinatown, it turns out, is not just about power and corruption.



Minute by minute

00:19

Evelyn Mulwray reveals to Jake Gittes, the private detective, that he has been duped in a ploy to discredit her husband, Hollis Mulwray.

00:42

After nearly drowning in a water channel, Gittes is threatened at knifepoint and his nose is slashed.

01:30

Gittes follows Mrs. Mulwray to a house in which her husband's "mistress" is staying. Mrs. Mulwray tells him that she is her sister.

01:57

Gittes arranges for Mrs. Mulwray and her sister to escape to Chinatown. He then confronts Noah Cross with the glasses.

00:00 00:15 00:30 00:45 01:00 01:15 01:30 01:45 02:10

00:31

Gittes turns up at the dam just as the police are pulling Mulwray's body out of the water.

01:15

Gittes and Mrs. Mulwray follow the paper trail of the property sales, which leads them to an old people's home. Gittes is shot at and narrowly escapes.

01:45

After finding the woman who had pretended to be Mrs. Mulwray dead, Gittes goes to the Mulwray house and finds a pair of glasses in the pond. He confronts Mrs. Mulwray, who tells him the shocking truth.